

Smart India Hackathon 2026 — the Institute is registered, and one team is ready

Briefing for faculty / the Programme Office · prepared by Harsh Bajpai · 17 September 2026

Every fact below was checked directly on sih.gov.in on 17 September 2026 — the public SPOC registry, the live problem-statement pages and the official College-SPOC guidelines PDF.

THE ASK, IN ONE LINE

IIM Mumbai is **registered** for SIH 2026, with a faculty SPOC in place. What stands between our team and a submission is a **nomination** — which requires an internal selection round and a signed letter on Institute letterhead, both before **30 September**. I am asking for those two things, and offering to do every part of the preparation that a student is allowed to do. **A clear no is still useful. Silence is the only bad outcome.**

TIME IS THE BINDING CONSTRAINT — UNDER TWO WEEKS

The portal closes for team nomination and idea submission on **30 September 2026**. That date is on **every problem-statement page on sih.gov.in**, and submissions are demonstrably open today.

One earlier guidelines PDF says 15th September. **It is superseded** — the current guidelines letter says 30th September twice, and the live portal agrees. I raise it only because the older file is still findable and would cause a needless panic.

What I verified (so nobody has to take my word for it)

- **IIM Mumbai is registered.** The public registry at sih.gov.in/know-your-spoc lists **3,002 institutes**, and the Institute is **row 89** — AISHE code **U-1283**, classified an Institute of National Importance, with **Dr. Puja Sarkar** as Single Point of Contact. I read it in the page source, not in a summary.
- **This registration is recent** — the row was absent when I checked on 11 September. So this briefing may be reaching someone who already knows all of it.
- **Our problem statement is open.** **SIH26171**, set by ISRO / Department of Space, stands at roughly **20 of the 500** submissions at which a statement freezes nationally — so room is not the risk, but the last day is not the day to submit either.
- **Management institutes are clearly eligible.** Welingkar (PGDM), Narsee Monjee and dozens of other management schools are registered, as is every IIT. There is no category question to resolve.

What remains, now that the Institute is registered

- **A faculty SPOC — already in place.** This step is done, and it was the one a student cannot perform.
- **An internal hackathon is mandatory.** Only teams selected in it may be nominated. My understanding is that no round is currently planned, and that very few teams are likely to apply — so a panel of two or three faculty and an hour would satisfy it.
- **The SPOC must upload an internal-hackathon report** of up to 15 pages: event overview, participating team and student counts, event photographs, jury panel and judges' details, judging process, news coverage, social-media promotion, and the nominated teams. **This is the heaviest item on the list.** I am offering to draft it in full, so that it reaches the SPOC as something to check and sign rather than something to write.
- **A nomination letter per team on Institute letterhead**, naming the team and all 6 members plus up to 2 mentors, signed by the Director/Dean and bearing the Institute seal.
- **Caps: 50 teams per college, 100 per university.** **U-1283 is a university-level AISHE code**, so the ceiling is 100. I am asking about one team.

The team rules, and how our team meets them

- **Exactly 6 student members.** We are six: Harsh Bajpai, Jinshri Jain, Vansh Khosla, Aarna Chauhan, Manas Bharadia and Siddhartha Chaudhary.
- **At least one female team member is mandatory.** We have two.
- **All members must be from the same college. Inter-college teams are not allowed.** All six of us are students of this Institute, so the team is nominable here and nowhere else.

- Up to 2 mentors (faculty or industry) are optional, and expected to have roughly 5 years' relevant experience.
- One team may submit against a maximum of 2 problem statements. Each problem statement freezes nationally once 500 ideas are received, so late submission carries a real risk of the statement closing.

Questions I need answered

Ordered so that a “no” to Q1 ends the matter quickly and costs the Institute nothing further.

1. Is the Institute willing to **nominate one team** for SIH 2026 before 30 September? A no is a complete answer and I will stop here.
2. Is an **internal selection round** being planned? If not, would a minimal one serve — two or three faculty on a panel, an hour, our demonstration and any other team that wishes to present? Only teams selected in such a round may be nominated.
3. May I **draft the internal-hackathon report** for the SPOC's review and signature? It is the longest document in the process, and it is work a student can do.
4. Who would **sign and seal the nomination letter** on letterhead — the Director, or a Dean? It names all six members and carries the Institute seal.
5. Who should complete the two official forms — the **College Consent Letter** and the **College Authorization Letter**? I hold both blank templates and have not altered them, because the template states that a changed format is grounds for disqualification.
6. Is there an **internal cut-off earlier than 30 September** that I should be working to instead of the national one?

What I am bringing — this is not a proposal, it is a working system

- **Problem Statement SIH26171**, set by **ISRO / Department of Space** — “On-device Visual Perception for Light-weight Browser Agents” (Software, Smart Automation). Our entry is called **Aavaran**; the team is **Vagabonds**.
- A browser extension plus a local server: an AI assistant that reads the screen and acts on it while **every PAN, Aadhaar number, card, password and face is removed on the user's own machine before anything is transmitted**.
- **It is built and running today**, in Chrome and Firefox, on two tagged releases, with automated tests passing on Linux, macOS and Windows.
- Measured on test pages never used during development, and separately on **ten real pages captured from the live web** — the income-tax portal, RBI, SEBI, UIDAI, MyGov: **100% detection accuracy, 100% precision, zero data leaks** on both; about 4.7 seconds per step on a deliberately slowed laptop. Every figure is reproducible with one command — none is an estimate.
- Field labels are handled in **eleven Indian languages**, not only English.
- For an internal selection round, this is a finished demonstrable product rather than a slide deck of intentions.

My honest assessment of the odds

I would rather set expectations correctly than oversell this.

- **Thirteen days is short** for a selection round, a report and a signed nomination, and the Institute may reasonably decide it is too short. I recognise that, and the heaviest item — the report — is the one I am offering to write.
- The realistic outcomes are: (a) the Institute nominates one team and we submit before 30 September; (b) it decides the process cannot be compressed this year, and the same groundwork stands for SIH 2027 with twelve months of notice instead of thirteen days; or (c) no answer arrives, which is the only outcome that wastes everybody's time.
- **The Institute's registration already has standing value** regardless of what happens to my team: SIH is an MoE/AICTE initiative, IIM Mumbai is now on the national list, and the nomination ceiling of 100 teams will still be there next year.

SOURCES AND CONTACTS — all checkable independently

SPOC registry (IIM Mumbai is row 89): sih.gov.in/know-your-spoc

Problem statements (each page carries the 30 September date): sih.gov.in/sih2026PS

Official guidelines: sih.gov.in/letters/2026/ — use the current *SIH 2026 Guidelines* letter; the file named *SIH2026-Guidelines-College-SPOC-updated.pdf* is the superseded one that says 15th September

AICTE / MIC: sih@aicte-india.org · hackathon@aicte-india.org

Problem statement: SIH26171 — ISRO / Department of Space